An Atlas of the Wayward

On South Street, two young women walking hand in hand along the sidewalk attracted the attention of the sociologist. His eyes settled on them, but they paid him no mind. One girl nudged the other with her elbow, and they stopped in front of one of the shops and peered into the window filled with rows of shoes. The large plate glass window allowed them entry into the world of radiant objects, and they too became part of the beautiful display. Their reflections floated on the surface of the glass, the brown faces resplendent as they hovered above the sea of items, lulled by the surfeit of goods. The shop window fascinated them and for a few moments interrupted their stroll while they gazed at the display window as if it were a moving picture. The glass window offered confirmation: Girl you look fine; chided: A threadbare coat can't fool anyone; instructed: Tilt that hat over the right eye, create the mystery you want to be.

Her eyes filled with longing, one of the women extended her arm, pointing toward a pair of men's shoes.

Do you see those shoes?

Which ones?

An assortment of men's shoes: conservative black wingtips, ankle-

high boots with silver eyelets, highly polished boots with complicated hooks, plain humble shoes, and heavy work boots. The shoes that caught her eyes were for the man who dared to exceed understatement, cared nothing about being respectable, and delighted in turning every head as he strode down the block. Who could resist a man in a pair of two-toned oxblood and ivory boots with buttons on the side?

With a pointed finger, she directed her companion's gaze.

Those?

That's the kind of shoes I'd buy my fellow.

The pair burst into laughter. Each one imagined the kind of man who would wear those shoes and the kind of woman she would have to be or become to stroll beside him. It wouldn't be a shy girl or a homely one, but a woman just as sharp and dangerous as he was. The kind of man who could get you to do the things you'd never do, even if you wanted to do them, without him being the excuse or setting down the law or acting the master, or the kind willing to get on his knees begging you to relinquish your boundaries to your desire: *Can I kiss you there?* Your brothers would hate him, rightly convinced that he would be the ruin of you, but the kind of man your girlfriends would desire and envy you for having. *She's not that pretty.* Loving that kind of man would make *your mother call you reckless and your father call you wild.*

He was the man the crowd opened up for, permitting the woman hanging on his arm to pass through, following alongside him or trailing behind him without having to push the jealous ones out of her path. The girl on his arm was no longer just a face in the crowd, but the face that the other women searched for, scorched with their evil looks and disfigured with their jealousy.

The shoes incited the fantasy of the man. For the shoes fit only the kind of man who raised your temperature with a gesture: the flick of his tongue over a dark, plum-colored bottom lip, or the way he perched his leg on the stoop and tugged at his trousers so that

his splendid shoes were on full display, or the way he tilted his head and set his mouth when he cast you a sideways glance. One of those roguish *Don't ask* types who arrogantly assumed they knew what you wanted, and if you had picked the right one, they did. He was the kind of beautiful, dangerous man who risked everything to keep his head raised, who would love you and leave you, the kind of man who talked *sweet*, trampled your heart, and left a trail of distraught lovers in his wake. The kind of man capable of far worse than he had done to you, so when he walked away, he felt decent and you considered yourself lucky for having survived love with only a few bruises to show for it and a handful of nasty words that still delighted you. The very idea of this wild break-you-down love thrilled the young women because they imagined it as *something akin to freedom*, the submission enjoyed by *the one who chose it*, a reckless act of self-expenditure.

Two colored girls, not yet futureless, desired a beautiful pair of shoes that lured them into a world so much better, so much bigger than ugly tenements and the press of poverty. They looked long and hard at all the objects on display in the shop window, expectant and dreaming of a way out.

The sociologist lingered at the corner of Seventh and Lombard, an onlooker determined not to let a single detail of the teeming life of the streets escape him. The intersection was the hub of Philadelphia's Black Belt, and from the corner he had a view of the worst slum in the city. Outfitted in a well-cut three-piece gray suit, with a gold timepiece nestled in the vest pocket and an elegant cane resting beneath his manicured hands, he looked every inch the dandy. Beneath the fashionable appearance beat the heart of a Victorian and a libertine. The cane and the gloves, a habit acquired as a student in Germany, were a shield and a second skin, which the twenty-eight-year-old Dr. W. E. B. Du Bois hoped might better protect the first. He was desperate to believe that the refinement of style might

make plain what escaped the gaze of the white world—every Negro was not the same. All noticed him on the corner, but no one stared or threw a stone at him.

Day and night, the streets bustled. The corner offered refuge to loafers, gamblers, thieves, and prostitutes, as well as stevedores, porters, day laborers, and laundresses. The raucous laughter and shouting that passed for conversation, and the loud irregular rhythms of ordinary life, were discordant to the ears of the investigator, and his head pounded from the assault. If not vigilant, he would be swallowed whole by the raw angry need, by the insistent hunger of the slum. Even beauty was an affront in these circumstances—the elegantly dressed boys and brash lovely girls, reckless enough to have staked every penny on an outfit.

He feared being engulfed by the crowd and cultivated detachment as his defense. The distaste was sharp and visceral. If there was hope to be found in the tumult and upheaval of the slum, in the waves of raw Negroes from the south, in the countrified excess, in the lust for more and better than this, in the ward's outlaw sounds, he searched for it. Who are these people? he wondered. *Just because I am a Negro doesn't mean I understand what these Negroes think or feel or want.*

The August heat was oppressive, suffocating. The stench of water closets and garbage-strewn streets forced him to take only shallow gulps of air. The summer weather, like the Seventh Ward, was intemperate and volatile, bright and clear one hour and stormy the next. In a moment, a wandering eye, an unwelcome joke, or a sharp retort could turn laughter into threats and curses. A loud and angry exchange erupted in the block, attracting his attention and that of the crowd. Two young men were embraced in battle. The pugilists locked arms around each other to ward off the damage of reciprocating blows. A young woman screamed as they rocked and lunged. Onlookers begged them to stop; others goaded them to destroy each other. A hat was knocked to the ground and a collar torn. With the flash of a blade, the crowd scattered. The Italian and Jewish peddlers

swung into motion, retreating from the danger and speedily navigating their rickety fruit and dry-goods carts away from the brawling Negroes. The white ladies from the College Settlement dared not enter the fray and diligently attended those waiting for lunch. The clamor of the street drowned out their welcome and defeated the platitudes, but soup was soup and the promise of a free meal beckoned even the recalcitrant. By the time the police arrived, the victim lay bleeding on the sidewalk and alone. No one had seen a thing.

Block after block of the ugly and unsightly was as sweet as freedom got. Three decades after Emancipation and black folks had nothing. No matter. The flood of migrants did not cease, and the scramble to live did not squelch dreams of the north, the city, and the good life. All they heard back home, in dusty southern towns, were the lies and the assurances—things were easier up there and the white folks ain't as evil. It took only a week to discover that neither was true. Still, it was better than Virginia or North Carolina. To the newcomers entering the city, the only lasting evidence of what the Civil War had won for them was their ability to catch a steamer north and roam the streets in search of opportunities that eluded them.

The Seventh Ward was marvel and blight, the heart of a ragtag black metropolis, the seed of the emergent ghetto. Philadelphia housed the largest black population in the northeast, until 1900, when New York's Black Belt surpassed it and Chicago replaced it as the second-largest city in the nation. But in 1896 it was still impressive. Since 1780, Philadelphia had been a laboratory for the nation's experiment in racial democracy and the premier stage on which *the future after slavery* was enacted. The city boasted a gilded history of triumph and accomplishment. The first act for the Gradual Emancipation of Slavery was passed in 1780. The Free African Society was established in 1787, and the doors of Bethel African Methodist Episcopal Church opened in 1794. The American Anti-Slavery Society was founded in 1833. Before the Civil War, the city was home to the

largest free black community in the country, and it boasted a small prosperous black elite. Then there was the underside: An outbreak of yellow fever in 1793 divided the city along racial lines. The black residents were blamed for the spread of the epidemic, conscripted to nurse the sick and cart the dead, and then excoriated for acts of theft and extortion rumored to have happened during the crisis. The Eastern State Penitentiary opened in 1829 and inaugurated the practice of solitary confinement. The first prisoner was Charles Williams, a Negro. In 1838, Negroes were disenfranchised after the state legislature decided that black and white citizens were not equal in the eyes of the law and changed the qualifications for suffrage in the state constitution from every freeman to every *white* freeman twenty-one and over who had paid taxes. Race riots in 1839, 1842, 1849, and 1871 rocked the city and tested the meaning of slavery and freedom, citizen and alien, on northern soil. Black men did not regain the right to vote until 1870, after the Fourteenth and Fifteenth Amendments were ratified. Octavius Catto, a young teacher and civil rights activist, had played a central role in the campaign to ratify the Fifteenth Amendment in Pennsylvania. In the election of 1871, he and other black men exercised this hard-won right in a vote for the Republican Party. After casting his ballot in Philadelphia, he was murdered by an Irish mob deputized by the police. After the 1876 compromise that ended Reconstruction and returned slavery to the south in the guise of debt peonage, sharecropping, domestic servitude, and the convict leasing system, waves of black migrants began arriving in the city. They rushed from the plantation and assembled in the streets.

Slick, fresh-mouthed boys, comely, buxom girls, policy runners, ne'er-do-wells, petty gangsters, domestics, longshoremen, and whores—the young and the striving, the old and the dissipated—gathered on the corner of Seventh and Lombard. The air was thick with laughter, boasts of conquest, lies bigger than the men who

told them. Idlers loud-talked one another in an orchestrated battle of words. Pimps crooned, "Hey girl, send it on" to each and every woman under thirty who strolled by. Bull daggers undressed the pretty ones with a glance. Passersby could overhear wishful stories shared about the good things yet to come. Hardworking folks and jaded pleasure seekers joked and despaired—this is the future we was waiting for?

The beautiful anarchy of the corner refused no one. It was the one place where they could quit searching and rest for a while, and still believe they were moving and on the way to some place better than this. Free association was the only rule and promiscuous social life its defining character. All were permitted to stay briefly, catch their breath, resist the pull of roaming, hustling, and searching. Every hour someone remarked, I got to go, and then lingered. Newcomers refreshed the crowd; strangers became intimates. The flow of those arriving and departing kept it alive. The same folks were always there and yet it always looked different.

Every rank and shade of black life could be seen in the Seventh Ward. A quarter of the Negroes in the city resided there. The aristocrats and the poor brushed elbows, not intimate (in fact, rarely on speaking terms), but forced by the color line to share the streets as well as the bottom rung of social life. The slum had spread from the Fifth Ward into the Seventh, expanding westward. Colored folks occupied the streets from Seventh to Eighteenth and from South Street to Spruce. They had remapped the ward, messing with the organization of the city by the ways they inhabited and used public space. Their political clubs, churches, rooming houses, barber shops, make-do establishments serving fried fish and biscuits, and saloons renowned for piano-playing, dance parties, easy women, dangerous men, sissies, and tribades had created the Black Belt in a northern city. Now the white folks wanted it back.

Falling-down tenements and alley dwellings sprouted in the shadows of Philadelphia's best homes. Ignorant Negroes and drunken

Irish willing to exchange a vote for a few dollars or a chicken dinner had decided the last mayoral election and defeated the reform candidate. The elites complained that political clubs merely provided cover for gambling and prostitution. Barbarians from the south had changed the face of the city and threatened to do more harm if the tide wasn't turned. The daily papers belittled the newly arrived migrants: they were unlettered country folk unsuited for modern life and intoxicated with dreams of freedom.

Concerned citizens, alarmed by the political corruption and crime in their city, held the growing population of black migrants responsible, so they hired him—a Harvard PhD and a Negro—to conduct a survey of the Seventh Ward, where they believed the cancer resided. Susan Wharton, the head of the College Settlement Association, and Dr. Charles Harrison, Provost of the University of Pennsylvania, invited the young social scientist to Philadelphia to write a comprehensive study of the Negro problem. The motives behind the invitation did not escape him. *There was a widespread feeling that something was wrong with a race responsible for so much crime.* It was clear that they wanted him to confirm what they already knew: The city was going to the dogs and the Negroes were to blame.

For a year, he and his new bride, Nina, were required to call a sparsely furnished one-room flat in the worst section of the Seventh Ward home. They were still shy lovers practicing the roles of husband and wife. He acted paternal, like a genial tyrant, as he imagined what a husband and head of the household should be. Nina, a beautiful dark-eyed slip of a girl, heeded his instructions, following his lead as if she were still his student. When he was a lecturer at Wilberforce, she had been a student enrolled in his classics course. At the beginning of the semester, he took notice of the delicate beauty. Utterly smitten by her lustrous black hair, hourglass figure, large trusting eyes, and cinnamon complexion, Du

Bois proposed, and by the end of the school year they were married. Her refinement and solid family background secured the match. Nina's father was a respected chef, and her Alsatian mother, an attentive and loving housewife who had cultivated her daughter's graceful and excellent manners. Du Bois doted on his bride, indulging her with small gifts and surprises. Eager to please, Nina was a fastidious housekeeper and devoted wife. She learned quickly to cede first place to his work and life out in the world.

700 Lombard Street—the College Settlement House—sat in the ugly heart of the slum. Here they lived alongside those he had come to study, residing in *an atmosphere of dirt, drunkenness, poverty, and crime.* The settlement house was built on the ruins of the notorious Saint Mary Street, another defeated project of slum clearance and urban renewal. "Model tenements" had once lined the street, offering the decent poor an example of how they should live, with charitable ladies, nurses, and friendly visitors, and the police providing the requisite instruction in uplift and betterment. (This time Susan Wharton intended to do a better job and not *labor blindly.*) When the old tenements were razed, the residents were scattered elsewhere, but little else had changed. The surrounding streets were packed with shiftless Negroes, a sprinkling of Russian and German Jews, and a handful of Italians. The College Settlement House replicated this earlier thwarted effort to improve the slum and uplift the Negro. But slum clearance only exacerbated the color line, displacing poor black folks who had occupied the worst blocks into the areas where the better class had fled, hoping to escape the conditions of less fortunate Negroes. *It was best not to clean a cesspool until one knew where the refuse could be disposed.* One slum disappeared and another emerged. The settlement workers and the housing reformers failed to realize that the slum was not a simple fact; it was a symptom of greater social and historical problems. Over the next two decades, the Negro quarter would become *the ghetto*—a racial enclosure, an open-air prison.

After one week's residence in the ward, Du Bois learned that murder was commonplace and the police were the only government. By the end of August, he knew not to get up and look out the window when he heard pistols firing. Two blocks away, the police had once rounded up forty-eight prostitutes in a morning's work. The *Inquirer* had reported that the raid in "Little Africa netted a courtroom full of women of all shades, from inky black to gold, all young, all tough, and all much given to swagger and vile oaths."

Poverty, crime, unemployment, overcrowding, lack of decent affordable housing, and broken families plagued the Seventh Ward. It exemplified the problems of the emergent black ghetto. Du Bois blamed the lax morals, promiscuity, children born out of wedlock, and the disregard of marriage for the social crisis or revolution of black intimate life that was taking place in the slum. The home, which had been destroyed by slavery, struggled to emerge after Emancipation, but it was at risk again. He blamed the plantation and the city for the sorry state of domestic life. The casual liaisons, transient marriages, and households that failed to conform to the pattern daddy-mommy-child disturbed him: unwed mothers raising children; same-sex households; female breadwinners; families composed of siblings, aunts and children; households blending kin and strangers; serial marriages; "widows" without legal standing; young women living out of wedlock with their lovers; lodgers and boarders acting as transient husbands; a man missing from one home resurfaced in another, raising a stranger's children as his own. *Cohabitation was a direct offshoot of plantation life and was practiced considerably.* Ten percent to twenty-five percent of the unions in the slum were common-law marriages, temporary cohabitation, and liaisons that lasted for two to ten years. Such kinship was labeled broken and immoral, and the home environment deemed unhealthy and a danger to society. Women assumed the duties of men, and men were dependent on the wages of their sisters, mothers, and wives to support families. Men searching for work left partners and children behind, started new

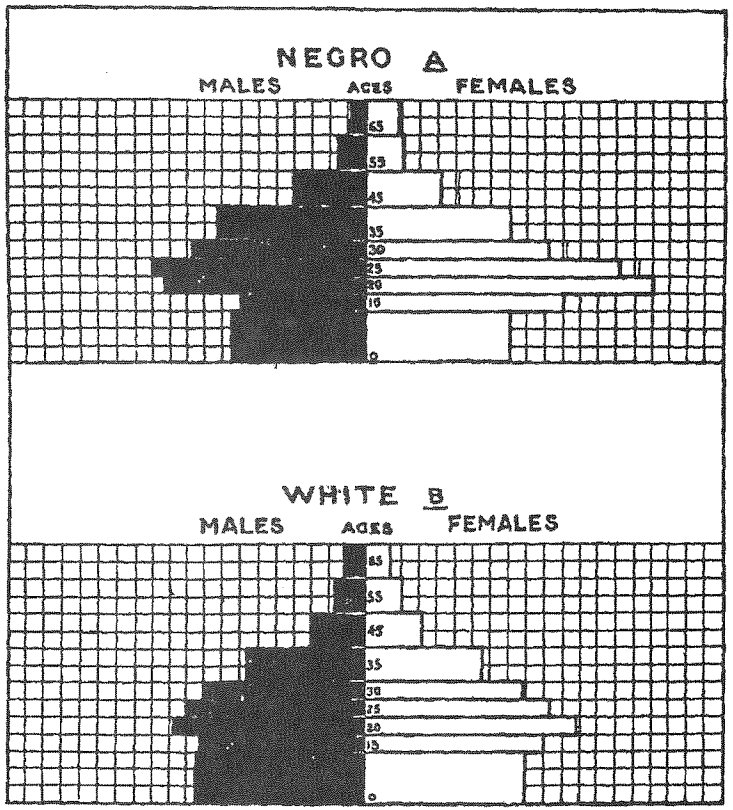
families elsewhere, and acted as substitutes for other men gone missing. Perhaps an aunt or lover or lodger did the same for him, taking on dependents and assuming obligations that others had abandoned or were unable to meet, yet such practices enabled survival. Flexible and elastic kinship were not a "plantation holdover," but a resource of black survival, a practice that documented the generosity and mutuality of the poor.

To the young sociologist, the tone of black social life was promiscuous. He blamed this condition on the disproportionate number of young folks and the surplus of young women who had migrated to the city—all of which encouraged free love and sexual excess. In this surplus, he envisioned *as deep and dark a tragedy as any in the history of human striving.* The rush to the city and the wandering from place to place in search of a better life had produced a social upheaval. Sixty percent of the black population was under thirty years of age. The tendency to marry later, economic distress, the high death rate of black men, and changing sexual mores were revolutionizing black intimate life. Women outnumbered the men. Charlotte Perkins Gilman, the writer and feminist, had first identified the danger of "cheap women" in the city. These surplus women were unable to secure marriage or produce proper families because the number of single women exceeded the available men. They troubled the marriage plot and produced nameless children.

The drama hiding behind the statistics and skewed gender ratios went something like this: Two young people not in a financial position to wed or support a family entered a thoughtless marriage. The husband, being unable to support the wife and now a child on his wages, needed her to work too; it was a state the sociologists described as being half a man. The couple struggled to survive and experienced marital strife, and then the wife turned laundress, or the husband deserted, or the couple chose to separate. Other scenarios included sexual promiscuity and men being supported by women. Du Bois feared that "armies of black prostitutes" and "undetected

prostitutes" passing for regular women were overtaking the race, such women figured prominently in his anxieties about the future.

The great numbers of unmarried women lowered the standards of life and fostered casual relations, cohabitation, the taking up and casting off of lovers at will. The lax moral habits of the slave regime were apparent in relationships broken by whim and desire. Casual sex was commonplace. Desertion, voluntary separation, and death explained the large number of homes without husbands and fathers. More than half the women in the ward were single, widowed, or separated, and this imperiled the newly fledged black family. Such were the fruits of sudden social revolution.



Men, unable to support families on low wages, ruined girls, abandoned mothers, and deserted wives. *So sudden a change in marriage customs posed grave dangers. Sexual looseness arose as a secondary consequence, bringing adultery and prostitution in its train.* Sexual immorality was a blot on the character of black folks. Slavery and the *utter disregard of a black woman's virtue and self-respect, both in law court and custom* were responsible for this shame, this wretchedness.

His views wavered, as the *heart-quality of fairness*, the heartbreak of shared sentiment, overtook the cold statistician. A betrayed girl-mother abandoned by her lover might embody all the ruin and shame of slavery and also represent all that was good and natural about womanhood. Du Bois equivocated regarding sexual freedom and decades later he came close to endorsing free love when it coincided with maternal desire. For him, motherhood would always be noble and virtuous because it was defined fundamentally by devotion, sacrifice, heroism, and the wealth of natural affection, which was distinct from selfish and carnal pleasures. He would come to embrace *betrayed girl mothers* and perceive *the up-working of new revolutionary ideals* in the choices they made and the way they lived. Circumstance forced his hand, leading him to recognize that black women's lives were not dictated by married motherhood and to accept that frank sexual longing was a sign of health in a culture that worshipped virgins and reviled whores. In a novel, he possessed the ability to transform a ruined girl who grew up in a brothel into a heroine, but achieving the same in a sociological study proved nearly impossible. Literature was better able to grapple with the role of chance in human action and to illuminate the possibility and the promise of the errant path.

No wall surrounded the Negro slum separating it from the rest of the world. The Jewish and Italian neighbors in the adjoining tenements weren't yet white. Their comfort and identity didn't yet

depend on restrictive covenants that prevented black folks from living on the block; they didn't yet relish the word *nigger*, or utter it with a pride and patriotism akin to waving the flag and with the certainty that the epithet as much as the stars and stripes established their position and security in the republic. The Negro quarter wasn't yet the dark ghetto, but each day a new stone was set in place. It was not yet a zone of racial enclosure characterized by extreme deprivation and regular violence. It was not yet a reserve for the dispossessed and those relegated as fungible, disposable, surplus, and not quite human. The ghetto was not yet a foregone conclusion. In two decades, this would no longer be true.

Every year more and more Negroes flooded the ward, concentrating the death and poverty of the city in the black quarter, making it harder to see beyond the slum or to dream of ever escaping it. The dirty streets and the poor housing conditions weren't the heart of the matter. The slum was the symptom of a problem 250 years in its evolution, but no one welcomed explanations that began with the arrival of twenty-odd Africans in Jamestown, Virginia, and went on to enumerate crimes that could never be forgiven. Three decades after Emancipation, freedom was an open experiment. For most white folks, it was still unthinkable and, at worse, it was a crime.

From his window one floor above the street, Du Bois watched his neighbors. The good elements mixed with bad and lived side by side in apparent harmony. To the indifferent eyes of the white world, they were all just Negroes, and nothing more. The poorest of them lined up for soup and bread at the settlement kitchen. From his perch, he could smell their poverty as keenly as he did the day's meal. Before him was a sea of black faces. Some were pinched by poverty, others, still open, were questing and bright. Day laborers, sullen and exhausted, trudged home, brushing past rawboned migrants awestruck by the sport and squalor of the ward. His eyes roamed from the group of idlers gathered on the corner to the reckless young women, and embittered old ones. On Lombard, on Kater, in Middle

Alley, folks gathered on the front steps of tenements enjoying the reprieve from the kitchen, the boss, the Missus, and the drudgery, if only for a few hours.

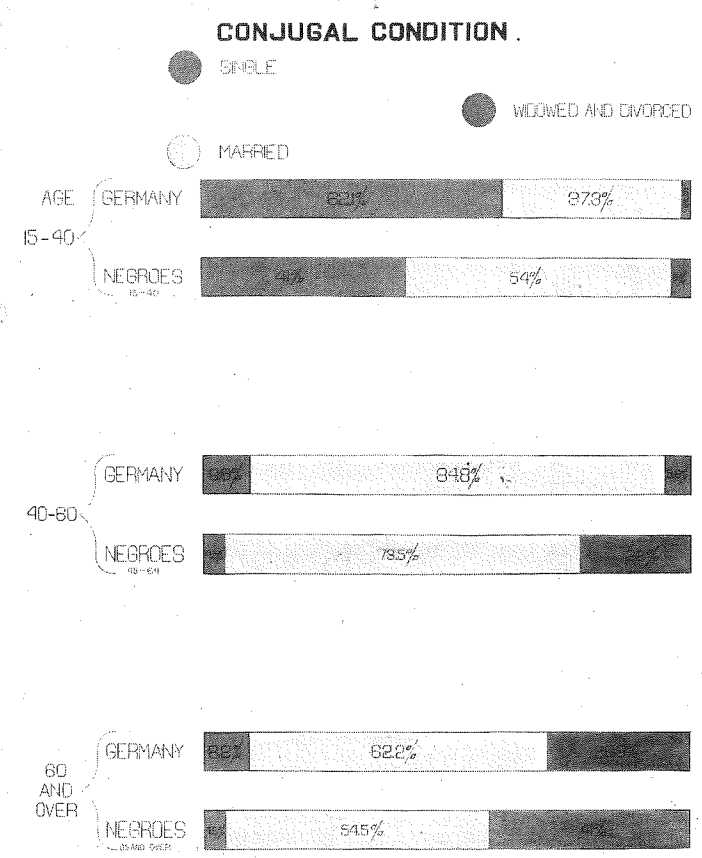
Not seen from his window were the women gathered in the courtyard, drinking cups of beer and playing cards. In one another's eyes, they were smart, crazy, wild, not to be messed with. They gossiped about the ones who had moved to New York, hoping to find a life better than Philadelphia had to offer, join the stage, or leave their troubles behind. The women swapped tales about the sharpers on the corner, cursed the no-good men not worth fighting over, they bragged about grinding all night, they lied that they were married, and never let on that their sister was really their girlfriend. *All pimps look alike to me*, one exclaimed, humming the popular tune. Yet the strident assertions—*I don't want him*; *you can have him*—and the full-bellied laughter that erupted after each anecdote shared about a beautiful, awful *no-count* man did not mask the tender silence that followed when the one talking the wildest confessed, *All I ever wanted was a nigger who would be true.* Yet the confidences shared in the courtyard and the collective knowledge of a woman's sorry condition would not prevent friends from coming to blows over a good-for-nothing Negro or taking up with another's husband. They delighted in rumor and created scandal by embellishing *he said* and *she said* until the truth was no longer possible to discern, but they sobered sharing the news of the day: the three colored policemen hired by the mayor, and the story in the paper about the colored milkman lynched in Ohio.

Had Du Bois seen the women from his window, they might have appeared spent and misshapen from the long day's work of cleaning up after white folks, lumbering home to squalid tenements and alley dwellings. The sight of a laundress, burdened with a basket of dirty clothes, slogging her way through the filth of the alley, might have encouraged his despair. The clop of her scuffed black boots was accompanied by oaths and curses muttered about this damn city.

A few men sat in open doorways, forced outside to escape stifling, airless rooms. Young women roamed the streets, adrift and headed for trouble. Where were their fathers and uncles and brothers? he wondered. Not the idle men lounging on the street in straw-backed chairs, or the thugs gathered on the corner. Where were the decent hardworking men? In this great industrial center, black men were locked out of the steel mill and the railroad yard, they were barred from the factories and the skilled trades. *They were loiterers on the ragged edge of industry.* The women outnumbered the men. This produced an unhealthy condition, encouraged women to couple casually, and men to take up and exchange women as it suited them. Statistics and ratios were not bloodless and abstract, but antagonists in the tragic tale of black womanhood.

In the graphs documenting the conjugal unions of black folks, the bars of the horizontal chart appeared like a banner; all that was missing in the black and gold bar graph of the "Mortality of American Negroes" was the red indexing the death and suffering that had produced this state of things. A hand-colored diagram provided a stark picture of the crisis, a visual document of an imperiled future. Nothing in the statistical tables asserted *me too* or risked being mistaken for an autobiographical example or required the sociologist to yield to the heartbreak of cold facts, although charts and graphs could prick as readily as any photograph. A whole world could be made and undone by a row of figures and the future eclipsed by ratios or the lines of a flowchart. The table of unions created, severed, and thwarted was a historical epic of love and trouble, a long chronicle of violation and unwanted touch. The lives crushed and destroyed appeared bloodless in the diagrams; the moral tableaus were cool, objective, no matter how devastating the social pictures they painted.

The women lured into prostitution and forced to sell themselves for ready cash disappeared into the column labeled *disorderly and bawdy houses.* Sex work was a crime masked by other categories, like



larceny and assault and battery. Under slavery, the law of property dictated that black women submit to any white man who wanted them; now poverty dictated their course. Black women, once sold, now were coerced to sell their bodies for ready cash. This new traffic in women bore the imprint of the older trade in human commodities. In the throes of the moral panic that ushered in the first decades of the twentieth century, reformers and the journalists decried prostitution as "white slavery" and so would the legislators and the prosecutors, yet there was nothing white about it, at least not as it concerned the black women of the ward, whose violated bodies and

exploited capacities were the norm, not the exception. Every one-dollar woman and fifty-cent whore working Ratcliffe Street or Middle Alley was another name entered in the ledger book.

The crushing weight of slavery had fallen on black women. Out of this, what sort of women could be born into the world of today? Adultery and degradation were their heritage and their condition today. What good could come from such women? It would take decades until Du Bois could find his way to an answer that didn't condemn them or forever consign them to a terrible fate. For the present, he concentrated on elaborating the social and historical forces that had produced the problem. A straight line could be traced from the plantation to the ghetto. Unlike his fellow sociologists content to *count the bastards and the prostitutes* and call it a day, he recognized the long history of sexual defilement that stamped the face of the present. Looking at the trail of exhausted women plodding their way home, he feared for the future. The world had relegated these women to an awful fate. He trembled at the sight of them.

The house-to-house canvass required him to put in eight- and nine-hour days surveying the ward and interviewing his neighbors. He had little experience with this type of poor urban Negro. Most had been in the city for only a few years, but already they had been scarred by the cold, hostile welcome of northern antipathy and hardened by the deprivations and brutality of the slum. They were nothing like the faithful, open peasants of the Tennessee hills whom he had taught during his summer breaks from Fisk University, where he first experienced an all-Negro world. The Dowells and the other families were united in the common hardship of poverty, but still they welcomed him, a stranger, and shared their scrupulously neat tiny homes and forced him to eat second helpings of their meals of fried chicken, wheat biscuits, corn pone, string beans, and berries. In the ward, such welcome was rare. When he knocked on doors

in the Seventh Ward, he often encountered flat withholding faces and eyes that were suspicious and doubtful. Long hard stares met his gaze. Most residents of the ward knew to be wary of the ones studying them.

How could he explain the purpose of his study: to educate the world about how the Negro lives and the reasons why we are forced to live as we do? Who was he? Nobody. He was just a stranger prying into their lives and asking intrusive questions. The white world, he wanted to tell them, is ignorant of our circumstances. If we educate them, we can change our condition.

In the 835 hours of conversation with five thousand people in the ward, they asked, *Why are you studying us?* Wouldn't it be better to study white folks, since they are the ones who need changing? They wondered what Negro was earnest or naive enough to believe that truth alone would change white people? As if they were blind to the world they had created? Or didn't know no better than to treat Negroes like dogs?

We ain't specimens!

The sight of an impeccably dressed colored man entering cellar dwellings, tenements, and alley houses did not go unnoticed. No doubt, the appearance of the effete gentleman making his way through the stinking back alleys of the ward amused some. Others distrusted his hincty manner and the standoffish way he held himself in their company. A few closed the door in his face; those less hostile participated reluctantly, giving terse answers to his questions, so the interviews lasted no more than fifteen minutes. The brothels and the gambling dens refused him entrance, as did the impeccable homes of the black elite, albeit for different reasons. This small upper echelon avoided the worst blocks, riding in their elegant hansoms; they preferred to maintain their distance from the lower ranks, to the extent that this was possible. They kept their distance from

him, holding the young sociologist at arm's length. Strangers rarely secured entrance to their circle. Many in this tier hardly even looked like Negroes and might best be described as whites with a small percentage of black blood.

Any race pride aroused by their success was mixed with disappointment. Their obsession with self-advancement, and their single-minded pursuit of wealth and comfort, blinded them to the condition of the lowest classes, except when inconvenienced or embarrassed by some new crisis or scandal created by the criminal element, but for which they too would be forced to pay.

"Are we animals to be dissected and by an unknown Negro at that?"

"Thank you for your time ma'am." He scribbled *unwilling to respond* on the schedule of questions.

"What's the object of this investigation?" the woman asked, eyeing him suspiciously.

"Simply to get at the truth," he answered.

"Do you propose to do anything after you get the facts?" she inquired.

"We simply collect the facts," he replied. "Others may use them as they will."

"Then you are trying only to get the facts and not to better things," she said.

"Yes," he answered.

"Humph," she replied and then refused to tell him anything.

"Why Negroes are doing badly—that's the mystery you trying to solve?"

When the laughter subsided, Du Bois proceeded with the next question.